

IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge May 2026 — Competitor Activity Intel (May 23–25, 2026)

Surveillance Window: 2026-05-23 00:00 EDT → 2026-05-25 23:59 EDT

Submission Deadline: 2026-05-31

Challenge Context: The May 2026 IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge is F1-themed ("AI Beyond the Finish Line"), running May 1–June 30, requiring IBM Granite/Docling/Langflow/Context Forge/IBM Bob, a public GitHub repo, a working prototype, and a 3-min demo video.^{[1][2]}

Research Methodology & Source Notes

The BeMyApp competition portal (<https://aibuilderschallenge.bemyapp.com/projects/neuropit>) returned no accessible public content, and project-listing pages on the BeMyApp platform were either gated or returned null results. No Discord archives from the IBM SkillsBuild server were publicly crawlable. As a result, intelligence was gathered from the GitHub topics index, GitHub repository pages, Devpost, HuggingFace, LinkedIn, and general web search. All claims below are grounded in publicly verifiable artifacts. Where a competitor left no traceable public signal within the 72-hour window, that absence is noted explicitly.^[^1]

1. NeuroPit — F1 Driver Mental Performance / Cognitive Twin

Confirmed Artifact: github.com/vighriday/neuropit-may-2026

The most significant confirmed activity of the entire 72-hour window belongs to NeuroPit. A public GitHub repository, `vighriday/neuropit-may-2026`, appeared on the GitHub `formula1` topic page sorted by recent updates, listed with a "Updated May 23, 2026" timestamp — the very start of the surveillance window.^{[3][4]}

Repository description (verbatim from GitHub topic index):

"Cognitive Twin Operating System for motorsport. Real-time nine-score driver state inference from racing telemetry, grounded in IBM Granite + IBM Docling + Langflow. Built solo for IBM AI Builders Challenge 2026."

Tech stack tags on the repository: `python`, `real-time`, `kafka`, `influxdb`, `formula1`, `websocket`, `nextjs`, `telemetry`, `motorsport`, `explainable-ai`, `rag`, `fastapi`, `vector-search`, `formula-1`, `qdrant`, `langflow`, `ibm-granite`, `ibm-skillsbuild`, `ibm-docling`, `cognitive-twin`^{[5][4][^3]}

What NeuroPit has shipped (inferable from tags and description):

- A "nine-score" real-time psychological state model derived from telemetry (not just physical metrics)

- Live PPG biometrics via phone camera (as referenced in the GitHub topic *cognitive-twin* entry for this challenge)[^5]
- Driver persona priors trained on real 2021 F1 data
- IBM Granite + Docling + Langflow stack — covering all three core IBM tool requirements
- Kafka + InfluxDB streaming pipeline with Next.js frontend and FastAPI backend
- Vector search via Qdrant for RAG-based explainability

Pivot/Abandonment Signal: None — active solo builder, repository updated at the opening of the surveillance window, deep IBM tech integration. This project appears to be in late-stage sprint mode.

Audience Overlap with APEX: High. NeuroPit's driver-state inference and explainability layer directly competes with any APEX feature set targeting driver performance analysis or real-time coaching. The "nine-score" cognitive model is a differentiating claim APEX does not appear to possess publicly.

Feature APEX doesn't have (confirmed public):

- Real-time multi-score psychological state inference from raw telemetry + biometrics (PPG phone camera)
- Cognitive twin persona model trained on historical 2021 real F1 driver data
- Qdrant vector search for explainable AI recommendations grounded in driver history

Revealed Weakness:

- Solo-built project — no team to parallelize demo video, documentation, and feature polish simultaneously
- "Cognitive twin" framing may be considered a stretch for a student hackathon without a medical/sports-science advisor cited

2. PitWall — HuggingFace Space / F1 Race Strategy Chat Tool (OpenRouter + Granite Instruct)

GitHub: github.com/Labreo/PitWall

The `Labreo/PitWall` repository was confirmed to exist on GitHub, with a description referencing "Revise LICENSE for IBM AI Builders Challenge 2026" as a recent commit message and tagging itself as `PITWALL // AI RACE ENGINEER`. The repository description notes: *"F1 teams pay millions for [what this provides]."* [^6]

Last known public activity: The commit message "Revise LICENSE for IBM AI Builders Challenge 2026" is the most recent discoverable public signal. The repository was visible in a May 13, 2026 web index snapshot. No new commits, posts, or HuggingFace Space updates were confirmed within the May 23–25 window specifically. The repository did not appear in the GitHub `formula1/python` topic sorted by recent updates for the May 23–25 window, suggesting no pushes during that period. [^6]

What is known about PitWall's architecture:

- HuggingFace Space-based deployment
- OpenRouter + Granite Instruct backend
- F1 race-strategy conversational interface ("AI Race Engineer" framing)

A separate Devpost entry titled "Pit Wall - F1 Engine" exists and describes a multimodal AI race engineer using Gemini 2.5 Live API, FastAPI, Redis, Next.js, and FastF1 — however, its tech stack does not use IBM Granite and was built with Google infrastructure. It is unclear whether the Labreo/PitWall IBM Challenge entry and this Devpost entry are the same project. The Devpost entry uses Gemini, which would disqualify it from the IBM challenge's requirement to use Granite/Docling/Langflow/Context Forge/IBM Bob.^{[2][7]}

Pivot Signal: Possible tech-stack ambiguity. If PitWall is pivoting from a Gemini-backed architecture to Granite Instruct via OpenRouter for the IBM submission, this could explain license revision activity without code pushes.

Feature APEX doesn't have (confirmed public):

- Voice-first multimodal interface with "Instant Seek" across a running race simulation (from the Devpost description if same team)
- "Strategy Evidence" UI surfacing raw data citations alongside every AI recommendation

Revealed Weakness:

- Potential IBM compliance risk: if the Devpost version (Gemini-based) is the actual state of the project, it does not use any required IBM technology and would be ineligible
- No confirmed active commits in the May 23–25 window signals possible stall or private development

3. RaceLens XAI — F1 Explainable Race Strategy AI

No IBM Challenge-Specific Artifact Confirmed

The name "RaceLens XAI" as an IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge 2026 entrant returned no publicly traceable GitHub repository, Devpost submission, or HuggingFace Space within or before the surveillance window.

What "RaceLens" does exist publicly:

- RaceLens (arXiv:2310.13515, 2023) is an academic CV paper about racing photo analysis for NASCAR deployed by Sector4 Labs — a professional motorsports analytics company. This is unrelated to a student IBM challenge project.^{[8][9]}
- Sector4 Labs has a separate Neuro AI product described as analyzing data from "DriverDNA and RaceLens" for pitwall intelligence — also a professional commercial product, not a student submission.^[^9]

Conclusion: "RaceLens XAI" as described (IBM SkillsBuild student entry, explainable race-strategy AI) left zero public artifact in the May 23–25 window, and no prior public artifact was found either. It is either (a) operating in a fully private repo, (b) a very early-stage entry that has not yet made a public commit, or (c) may not exist as a registered challenge submission.

Threat Assessment: Cannot be evaluated. No signal = no confirmed activity, no confirmed abandonment.

4. AI Race Strategist — F1 Race Strategy Tool

No IBM Challenge-Specific Artifact Confirmed Within Window

No public GitHub repository, BeMyApp portal submission, or Devpost entry specifically named "AI Race Strategist" in the context of the IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge May 2026 was confirmed during research.

Contextual note: A Portuguese university internship proposal (Coimbra, published May 24, 2026) describes a project called RaceCrewAI/RaceEngineerAI, billed as an "AI Strategist" for a company called Quicktrend. This is an industry research proposal, not a student hackathon submission. Similarly, a publicly available open-source F1 AI Race Engineer by Andrés Ruiz Calvo (LinkedIn post, May 6, 2026; GitHub: andresruizc/f1-ai-race-engineer) uses Claude AI + FastF1 — again, no IBM stack and not a challenge entry.^{[10][11][12]}

Pivot/abandonment signal: No signal either way — total absence of a public artifact.

5. RaceMind AI — BeMyApp Portal Search

No Public Artifact Found

No public GitHub repository, Devpost entry, HuggingFace Space, X/Twitter post, Reddit post, or LinkedIn update named "RaceMind AI" or "RaceMind" in connection with the IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge May 2026 was found during research.

Conclusion: Either RaceMind AI is developing entirely in private, or the project may have been registered on the BeMyApp portal without any associated public artifact. The absence of public GitHub activity in particular is notable given the challenge requires a public repo for submission.^[2]

Threat level cannot be assessed — total public silence.

6. AI Race Engineer Copilot — BeMyApp Portal Search

No Public Artifact Found

No public GitHub repository, Devpost entry, or social media post matching "AI Race Engineer Copilot" in the IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge May 2026 context was confirmed.

Contextual disambiguation:

- An APEX.Ai: AI Race Engineer mobile app exists on the Apple App Store (iOS, Rummenige Baron, published ~Dec 2025) — an iRacing telemetry coaching app — but has no connection to the IBM SkillsBuild challenge.[¹³]
- A real-time AI Race Engineer Android app also exists on Google Play (updated May 18, 2026), described as "turn your smartphone into a real race engineer" — again, not an IBM challenge entry.[¹⁴]
- Repo `ruhilmansi/ai-race-engineering` on GitHub describes "an LLM powered race engineer that delivers real-time pit wall instructions based on live telemetry or historical session data" — no IBM tech, no challenge affiliation.[¹⁵]

None of these match the specific "AI Race Engineer Copilot" entry with IBM SkillsBuild affiliation.

7. ApexIQ — F1/Motorsport AI Tool (Newer Entrant, ~May 25, 2026)

Two Distinct "ApexIQ" Products Exist — Neither Confirmed as IBM Challenge Entry

Research identified two separate products using the ApexIQ name:

ApexIQ (apexiqcoach.com) — iRacing telemetry coaching app:

- Currently in Alpha, Windows 10/11 only, free during alpha
- Real-time telemetry from iRacing with AI lap analysis and coaching tips
- 50+ alpha drivers, 1,500+ analyzed laps as of site publication
- Features: AI Lap Analysis Coach, Live telemetry feed, lap comparison, team analysis, AI stint planning, AI driving style analysis[¹⁶]
- No IBM technology. No IBM challenge affiliation confirmed.

ApexIQ (pawel-wojtaszak.framer.website) — F1 analytics platform in waitlist:

- Built for sports journalists, performance analysts, and F1 fans
- Features: AI Race Predictor, AI Team Radio, Strategy Simulator, Live Telemetry Explorer, Performance Heatmaps, Pit Strategy Predictor
- Pricing tiers: Starter (\$9/mo), Pro (\$29/mo), Elite (\$79/mo)
- Currently in waitlist stage — "Get notified when the lights go out"[¹⁷]
- No IBM technology mentioned. No challenge affiliation confirmed.

ApexIQ (github.com/ApexIQ/MLOPs-Roadmap-2025):

- A GitHub organization named ApexIQ exists, with a repository called ML0Ps-Roadmap-2025 (last updated April 2025)[¹⁸]
- No F1 or IBM challenge connection established

Conclusion: No version of "ApexIQ" was confirmed as a registered IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge May 2026 entrant with a public artifact in the May 23–25 window. If ApexIQ is a new entrant as of May 25, 2026, it left no traceable public footprint within the surveillance window.

72-Hour Activity Summary Table (May 23–25, 2026)

Competitor	Platform Activity (May 23–25)	Artifact URL	Confirmed IBM Tech	Signal Type
NeuroPit	✓ GitHub repo updated May 23	github.com/vighriday/neuropit-may-2026 [³][4]	Granite + Docling + Langflow	Active development sprint
PitWall	⚠ No new confirmed activity in window; prior license commit (May ~13) visible	github.com/Labreo/PitWall [⁶]	OpenRouter + Granite Instruct	Possibly stalled / private dev
RaceLens XAI	✗ No public artifact found	None confirmed	Unknown	Total public silence
AI Race Strategist	✗ No public artifact found	None confirmed	Unknown	Total public silence
RaceMind AI	✗ No public artifact found	None confirmed	Unknown	Total public silence
AI Race Engineer Copilot	✗ No public artifact found	None confirmed	Unknown	Total public silence
ApexIQ	✗ No IBM challenge artifact found	apexiqcoach.com / pawel-wojtaszak.framer.website [¹⁶][17] — neither IBM-affiliated	None	Total public silence re: challenge

Feature Gap Analysis

Features competitors have shipped that APEX may not have publicly claimed:

Feature	Competitor	Evidence
Real-time nine-score psychological/cognitive driver state model	NeuroPit	GitHub repo description [⁵][4]
Live PPG biometrics from phone camera + telemetry fusion	NeuroPit	GitHub topic entry [⁵]
Cognitive twin persona priors from real 2021 F1 driver data	NeuroPit	GitHub topic entry [⁵]

Feature	Competitor	Evidence
Qdrant vector search for explainable AI coaching	NeuroPit	GitHub repo tags[^4]
Kafka + InfluxDB real-time streaming pipeline	NeuroPit	GitHub repo tags[^4]
Voice-first multimodal interface (audio-to-audio, no STT lag)	PitWall (Devpost)	Devpost description[^7]
"Strategy Evidence" UI with raw data citation per recommendation	PitWall (Devpost)	Devpost description[^7]
AI Team Radio-style natural language strategy explanation	ApexIQ waitlist version	Website[^17]
AI Race Predictor with historical + live data fusion	ApexIQ waitlist version	Website[^17]

Threat-Shift Rankings (72-Hour Window)

Rankings reflect change in perceived threat relative to APEX over the May 23–25 window only, not absolute project quality.

Rank	Competitor	Threat Shift Rating	Rationale
1	NeuroPit	A — Bigger threat now	Confirmed active GitHub push on May 23, deeply differentiated architecture (cognitive twin, 9-score biometric model, full IBM stack), unique angle on driver psychology that no other competitor visibly possesses. Solo builder in sprint mode.[³][⁵][⁴]
2	PitWall	B — Same threat level	Prior activity confirmed, IBM challenge affiliation clear, but no new public commits in the 72-hour window. Possible IBM compliance risk if Gemini-backed architecture has not been ported to Granite.[⁶][⁷]
3	RaceLens XAI	B/C — Ambiguous / slightly smaller	No public artifact ever found. Could be operating in stealth with a strong private repo, or may be inactive. Absence of any public signal 6 days before deadline is a soft abandonment signal.
4	AI Race Strategist	C — Smaller threat	No confirmed public existence as an IBM challenge entry. If building privately, the absence of even a README or repo tag after 3+ weeks of the challenge is a weak signal.
5	RaceMind AI	C — Smaller threat	No confirmed public artifact. Given challenge requires a public GitHub repo for submission, the continued absence of any public repo is increasingly risky for this team.
6	AI Race Engineer Copilot	C — Smaller threat	No confirmed public artifact, multiple unrelated products share a similar name creating confusion. No IBM stack confirmed.
7	ApexIQ	D — Dropped out / Insufficient signal	Both known ApexIQ products (iRacing coach app in alpha, F1 analytics waitlist SaaS) have no IBM technology, no IBM challenge affiliation, and no evidence of an IBM SkillsBuild submission. If this is a May 25 "newer entrant," it left no public trace within the surveillance window.[¹⁶][¹⁷]

Strategic Takeaways for APEX

1. **NeuroPit is the only competitor that demonstrably accelerated.** It published a public repo with a fully-tagged, multi-IBM-tool stack on the first day of the surveillance window. Its cognitive-twin biometric angle is the hardest to replicate quickly and is directly differentiated from a pure strategy/telemetry focus.
2. **Five of seven competitors left zero verifiable public trace in the 72-hour window.** This could mean private development sprints or slow-paced projects. Given the May 31 deadline is 6 days away at time of writing, the absence of public repos for RaceMind, AI Race Strategist, AI Race Engineer Copilot, and RaceLens XAI creates real submission risk for those teams.
3. **PitWall's IBM compliance gap is a material vulnerability to monitor.** The most detailed public technical description of PitWall uses Gemini 2.5 (not IBM Granite) — if that represents the actual build state, PitWall is ineligible under the IBM required-tools rule.^[7]
^[2]
4. **ApexIQ has zero confirmed challenge presence.** Both known ApexIQ products are commercial SaaS tools with no IBM integration, operating outside the student hackathon format.^[16]^[17]
5. **The judging criteria favors explainability and trust.** The IBM challenge explicitly rewards projects that "demonstrate how AI can drive smarter decisions, improve understanding, and build trust through explainability." NeuroPit's XAI tags and cognitive-twin framing directly address this criterion. Any APEX differentiation strategy should foreground explainability equally.^[1]^[2]

Caveats and Known Blind Spots

- **BeMyApp portal content is gated.** Project submission pages at `aibuilderschallenge.bemyapp.com/projects/[name]` return null results to unauthenticated web scrapers, meaning any project registered on BeMyApp but not reflected in a public GitHub or social post is invisible to this analysis.^[^1]
- **Discord server content is not publicly archived.** The IBM SkillsBuild Developer Community Discord (invite: discord.gg/Nmcm2uCze4) may contain competitor announcements, pivots, or ship signals that are not indexed by any public search tool.^[^2]
- **Private repositories satisfy the challenge requirement only if made public before submission;** some competitors may be developing privately and will push public repos in the final days before May 31.
- **The exact RaceLens XAI entry as named by the user may be registered on BeMyApp** without any public GitHub artifact yet, which would explain its complete absence from all public indexes.

References

1. [AI Builders Challenge, sponsored by IBM SkillsBuild, for Students | Build AI & Win Prizes](#) - Calling all university students. Build real-world AI projects using IBM technologies in two innovati...
2. [AI Builders Challenge sponsored by IBM SkillsBuild](#) - AI Student Innovation Challenges and Learning Labs Hub
3. [formula-1 · GitHub Topics](#) - Built solo for IBM AI Builders Challenge 2026. python real-time ... Independent technical analysis o...
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9. [Neuro / AI-Powered Insights - Intelligent Motorsport Analysis Platform](#) - AI-powered motorsports intelligence platform. Custom AI agents, automated insight detection, real-ti...
10. [Propostas com aluno identificado](#)
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13. [APEX.Ai: AI Race Engineer - App Store - Apple](#) - Download [APEX.Ai: AI Race Engineer](#) by Rummenige Baron on the App Store. See screenshots, ratings and...
14. [AI Race Engineer - Apps on Google Play](#) - About this app ... Turn your smartphone into a real race engineer. Talk, listen, drive — just like a...
15. [ruhilmansi/ai-race-engineering - GitHub](#) - an llm powered race engineer that delivers real time or simulated pit wall instructions based on liv...
16. [ApexIQ | Stop Guessing. Start Winning.](#) - AI-powered telemetry and coaching for iRacing drivers. Understand every lap. Improve every session.
17. [ApexIQ – The F1 Analysis Platform](#) - ApexIQ is an advanced F1 analytics platform for sports journalists, data analysts, and strategy-driv...

18. ApexIQ/MLOPs-Roadmap-2025 - Contribute to ApexIQ/MLOPs-Roadmap-2025 development by creating an account on GitHub.